

Gov. and Politics of Japan - Subject: Japan's Framing of Atrocity

When considering postwar political legitimacy in countries such as Japan and the United States, it is essential to examine how wartime atrocities shape public perception. Incidents such as the use of comfort women, the Rape of Nanjing, and the bombing of Hiroshima encapsulate political struggles in which leaders must frame themselves as “right” while confronting histories of violence. I argue that these controversies reflect both unresolved imperial ideology and contemporary political strategy, as denial and framing allow states to avoid fully acknowledging atrocities that would undermine their legitimacy.

First, in examining the use of comfort women, Japan's postwar political legitimacy hinges on whether the state can be held responsible for systematic abuse rooted in unresolved imperial ideology. While military prostitution already existed, Japan represented “an extreme case of systematic exploitation of women by the state” (Hayashi, *Comfort Women*). This distinction matters because it shows that the comfort women system was not an incidental product of war, but a product of the structures that treated colonized populations as expendable resources. However, Hayashi further notes that “the Japanese government had denied its involvement in and responsibility for this system until 1992,” despite evidence revealing “the deep involvement of the Japanese army and government in the creation, control and management of the comfort-women system” (Hayashi, *Comfort Women*). Japan's lack of accountability, rather than confronting how state authority enabled systematic abuse, reflects the persistence of imperial ideology in its memory politics. This strategy closely resembles that of the United States, where historical comparison and omission have been used to minimize responsibility for

atrocities such as slavery. In both cases, political institutions manage narratives of exploitation through denial or selective acknowledgment in order to preserve legitimacy.

Furthermore, the Japanese response to the Rape of Nanjing demonstrates the contemporary political strategy employed in managing these controversies. Many Japanese officials and historians “deny there was a massacre on such a scale,” admitting that deaths and rapes occurred, but arguing they were “on a much smaller scale than reported” and that such violence happens “in times of war” (BBC, *Scarred by History*). Additionally, Japanese institutions such as Nippon Kaigi have worked to dispute wartime responsibility and omit accounts of these atrocities from education entirely. A similar pattern of omission can be observed in the United States’ handling of Hiroshima and Nagasaki, where postwar censorship limited discussion with “no information about the physical and human damage inflicted by the bombings,” leaving “most Japanese outside Hiroshima and Nagasaki” with “little or no knowledge of what an atomic bomb was—including radiation effects” (Freeman, *Lecture*). Through these practices of information control, both Japan and the United States have employed political strategies to manage public understanding of wartime atrocities in order to protect national reputation.

When considering these atrocities collectively, both Japan and the United States should offer formal apologies. However, for such apologies to contribute to reconciliation, they must be accompanied by institutional change, including revisions to education policy, official statements, and public commemoration that shows responsibility. Without these facets, apologies risk appearing strategic or insincere, which can deepen conflict rather than resolve it. This dynamic has appeared historically, as Tanaka observes that “a hidden aim of Obama’s visit to Hiroshima—and of Abe’s visit to Pearl Harbor—was to celebrate their mutually accepted denial

of respective war responsibilities,” a denial that remains “crucial to the foundation of the U.S.–Japan military alliance” (Tanaka, *Mutual Complicity*). In this way, apology functions as reconciliation only when it sparks change, rather than reinforcing strategic silence for political convenience.

Works Cited

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